

doc-tritheism-denial

Affirms · Theology Proper › Trinity · doctrine · unanimous_lineages · confidence: high

Statement under examination

The three Persons of the Trinity share one divine essence; they are not three separate gods.

Rationale

Pan-canonical lexical monotheism: Hebrew echad H259 in the Shema (Deut 6:4) with YHWH H3068 and Elohim H430, reinforced by ein od H369 plus H5750 in Isa 45:5-6, 14, 18, 21-22 and Isa 46:9 ('I am God and there is no other'). The Greek network mirrors: heis G1520 ho theos in Mark 12:29-32 (Jesus' own affirmation of the Shema), 1 Cor 8:4-6 (ouk estin theos ei me heis), 1 Tim 2:5 (heis gar theos), and Jas 2:19 (heis estin ho theos). The triadic-yet-singular formula in Matt 28:19 uses the singular noun onoma G3686 ('name', not 'names') governing the three distinct articulated persons (tou patros, tou huiou, tou hagiou pneumatos), and 2 Cor 13:14 places the three together in one apostolic benediction. The canon does not present three gods; it presents one God whose self-disclosure is irreducibly triadic.

Reasoning

Verdict: The Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit are not three gods. They are one God who exists in three persons. The strongest reason from Scripture is that the Bible says over and over that there is only one God. Deuteronomy 6:4 is the daily prayer of Israel: 'Hear, O Israel, the LORD our God, the LORD is one.' Isaiah 45:5 says, 'I am the LORD, and there is no other; besides me there is no God.' Isaiah 46:9 says, 'I am God, and there is no other.' Jesus himself quotes the prayer of Deuteronomy 6 in Mark 12:29, and a Jewish scribe agrees with him that God is one. Paul writes in 1 Corinthians 8:6, 'For us there is one God, the Father, from whom are all things, and one Lord, Jesus Christ, through whom are all things.' 1 Timothy 2:5 says, 'There is one God.' James 2:19 even says that the demons believe God is one and shudder. The strongest tension inside Scripture is that the Bible also speaks of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit as if they are distinct. The Father sends the Son. The Son prays to the Father. The Spirit proceeds from the Father. At Jesus' baptism in Matthew 3 the Father speaks from heaven, the Son comes up from the water, and the Spirit descends like a dove. In the great commission Jesus tells the disciples to baptize in 'the name' (singular) of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. The verdict handles this tension exactly the way the Bible itself does. The three are not three gods because the Bible never lets us count past one when it talks about God's being. The three are also not just names or roles of one person, because they speak to one another, send one another, and love one another. The traditional language is that God is one in being and three in persons. That language goes beyond the Bible's exact words, but it does not go beyond the Bible's pattern. Tritheism collapses the first half of the pattern, the strict 'there is no other God,' and that is why it is rejected.

Denominational landscape

Every major historic Christian lineage rejects tritheism. This is one of the most unanimous teachings in all of church history. The Nicene Creed of 325, refined at Constantinople in 381, opens 'We believe in one God,' and then names the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit as the one God. The Athanasian Creed states the formula directly: 'we worship one God in Trinity, and Trinity in Unity; neither confounding the persons nor dividing the substance.' The Cappadocian fathers (Basil of Caesarea, Gregory of Nyssa, Gregory of Nazianzus) developed the formula 'one being (ousia), three persons (hypostases)' precisely to rule out both modalism on one side and tritheism on the other. Augustine's De Trinitate works the same problem from the unity end. The Catholic Catechism teaches the Trinity as one God in three persons.

Lutherans confess in the Augsburg Confession Article I that there is one Divine Essence, eternal and indivisible, called the Father, the Son, and the Holy Ghost. Anglicans in the 39 Articles Article I confess 'one living and true God' with the three persons of one substance. The Reformed confessions (Westminster, Belgic, Heidelberg) say the same. Methodists in the Articles of Religion repeat the formula. Anabaptists at Dordrecht confess one eternal almighty God Father, Son, and Holy Ghost. Pentecostals in the Assemblies of God Statement of Fundamental Truths Truth 2 affirm 'The one true God has revealed himself' as Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. Eastern Orthodoxy holds the same Nicene-Cappadocian formula and is exceptionally careful about it. The public-record carriers of explicit denial are outside historic Christianity. Mormonism (the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints) explicitly teaches three distinct gods who are one in purpose but not one in being. Joseph Smith's King Follett Discourse teaches a plurality of gods directly. On the bare proposition that there is one God in three persons rather than three separate gods, historic Christianity speaks with one voice.

Position thresholds

Would die for if challenged	Yes
Cult marker if denied	Yes
Would visit if otherwise	No
Would participate if otherwise	No
Would serve if otherwise	No
Would be member if otherwise	No
Would let children be taught otherwise	No
Would marry if held otherwise	No
Would publicly correct if otherwise	Yes

Notes

Tritheism (three separate gods) collapses the Shema and the entire prophetic monotheism of Isaiah 40-48 and is therefore a denial of the foundation of biblical religion, not a secondary precision dispute. Public-record carriers of explicit tritheism are rare in the Christian tradition because historic orthodoxy from Nicaea forward has explicitly rejected it. The clearest contemporary public-record carrier is Mormonism (the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints), which teaches that the Father, the Son, and the Holy Ghost are three distinct beings who are 'one in purpose' but not one in substance or being. Joseph Smith's King Follett Discourse (1844) explicitly teaches a plurality of gods. Some popular Christian preaching drifts toward functional tritheism (three beings who happen to cooperate) without meaning to; this is a precision-vs-fruit error rather than a Mormon-grade doctrinal commitment. The lexical bar is exceptionally clean: Deut 6:4 plus Isa 45:5 plus 1 Cor 8:6 plus Jas 2:19 form an iron-tight pan-canonical pattern that no honest reader can dissolve.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. nicene_trinitarianism, cappadocian_trinitarianism, augustinian_trinitarianism, social_trinitarianism, mormon_polytheism

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

Competing lens verdicts

· affirms:

· affirms:

· affirms:

· affirms:

· denies:

Verdict rests on a pan-canonical lemma network for monotheism (echad H259, ein od H369 plus H5750, ephes H657, heis G1520 ho theos) and a parallel pan-canonical pattern of triadic-yet-singular speech (Matt 28:19 singular onoma over three persons, 2 Cor 13:14 apostolic benediction, 1 Cor 12:4-6 parallel triad, Eph 4:4-6 sevenfold one). Analogia scripturae is invoked to handle the Gen 1:26, Gen 3:22, and Ps 82 plural-language complications: the canon's broader strict monotheism (Deut 6:4, Isa 45:5, Jas 2:19) forces those plural expressions to be read as internal to the one God, not as a polytheistic council. Progressive revelation factors in: the Old Testament establishes strict monotheism and contains hints of internal complexity (Gen 1:26, Ps 110:1, Prov 8, Isa 9:6), and the New Testament makes explicit that the three are Father, Son, and Holy Spirit while preserving the one-God affirmation (1 Cor 8:6 splits the Shema across Father and Son without breaking it). The Cappadocian-Augustinian formulation goes beyond the lexical surface but does not violate it; it labels what the canon teaches.

Scripture (apparatus + interlinear)

Deut.6.4 · for · genre: law

Key term. דְּחָא הוּא־יְהוָה יְהוָה יְחִיד; YHWH H3068; Elohim H430; echad H259

Force. echad H259 = one, single, united. The Shema, the daily confession of Israel. 'Hear, O Israel, the LORD our God, the LORD is one.' echad is the same word used of husband and wife becoming 'one flesh' in Gen 2:24 (compound unity is possible within its semantic range, but the primary force here is the strict denial of any other god alongside YHWH)

Isa.45.5 · for · genre: prophecy

Key term. יֵאֵן הוּא־יְהוָה וְלֹא יִהְיֶה עִמָּי אֱלֹהִים אֲחֵרִים; ein H369; od H5750; zulati

Force. ein od = there is no more, none besides. zulati = apart from me, except me. 'I am the LORD, and there is no other; besides me there is no God.' The clearest first-person divine denial of any other deity in the Hebrew Bible, repeated four times in Isa 45 alone (vv.5, 6, 14, 18, 21, 22)

Isa.46.9 · for · genre: prophecy

Key term. וְיִנְמַכְךָ כְּמִנְיָי וְלֹא יִהְיֶה עִמָּי אֱלֹהִים אֲחֵרִים; El H410; ein H369; ephes H657

Force. ephes H657 = end, cessation, nothing; with kamoni = like me. 'I am God, and there is no other; I am God, and there is none like me.' Concordance reinforcement of the Isa 45 pattern. The doubled negation (ein od + ephes kamoni) is the canonical seal on strict monotheism

Mark.12.29 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. κύριος ὁ θεὸς ἡμῶν κύριος εἷς ἐστίν; kyrios G2962; heis G1520

Force. heis G1520 = one (numeral). Jesus' own answer to the question about the greatest commandment: he quotes the Shema in full. 'Hear, O Israel, the Lord our God, the Lord is one.' The scribe agrees (v.32, 'He is one, and there is no other but he'), and Jesus commends him. Jesus' personal endorsement of canonical monotheism

1Cor.8.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. εἷς θεὸς ὁ πατήρ ... καὶ εἷς κύριος Ἰησοῦς Χριστός; heis G1520

Force. Paul's deliberate split of the Shema's Adonai (kyrios) and Elohim (theos) across the Father and the Son, both governed by heis. 'For us there is one God, the Father, from whom are all things, and one Lord, Jesus Christ, through whom are all things.' Strict monotheism preserved while the Son is included inside the divine identity. The Holy Spirit appears in the same configuration two chapters later (1 Cor 12:4-6)

1Tim.2.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. εἷς γὰρ θεὸς εἷς καὶ μεσίτης θεοῦ καὶ ἀνθρώπων; heis G1520

Force. 'For there is one God, and there is one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus.' Pauline reaffirmation of strict monotheism inside the gospel proclamation itself. Concordance reinforcement of the heis theos pattern

Jas.2.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. σὺ πιστεύεις ὅτι εἷς ἐστίν ὁ θεός; heis G1520

Force. 'You believe that God is one; you do well. Even the demons believe and shudder.' James presupposes that the truth that God is one is shared even with the unfaithful spiritual beings. Concordance reinforcement and a sober warning that bare assent to monotheism without works is insufficient. Confirms the proposition is canonical not just confessional

Matt.28.19 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. εἰς τὸ ὄνομα τοῦ πατρὸς καὶ τοῦ υἱοῦ καὶ τοῦ ἁγίου πνεύματος; onoma G3686

Force. onoma G3686 is grammatically singular ('name', not 'names'), governing three distinct articulated persons (tou patros, tou huiou, tou hagiou pneumatos). The single shared name across three persons is the canon's own anti-tritheist formula: not three names of three gods, one name of three persons. The great commission's baptismal formula presupposes the Trinitarian-monotheist structure

2Cor.13.14 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. ἡ χάρις τοῦ κυρίου Ἰησοῦ Χριστοῦ καὶ ἡ ἀγάπη τοῦ θεοῦ καὶ ἡ κοινωνία τοῦ ἁγίου πνεύματος

Force. Paul's apostolic benediction places the Lord Jesus Christ, the God (the Father), and the Holy Spirit together as one source of grace, love, and fellowship. Concordance reinforcement of the triadic structure inside an apostolic prayer-formula. The three are distinct (different prepositional phrases) but the blessing is one

Deut.4.35 · for · genre: law

Key term. יְהוָה דָּוַע נִין מִלְּאָה אוֹה הוּא; ein H369; od H5750

Force. 'The LORD is God; there is no other besides him.' Same ein od construction as Isa 45 and 46. Concordance reinforcement: the strict-monotheism formula is not only Isaianic; it is foundational Mosaic teaching at the renewal of the covenant before entering the land

Deut.4.39 · **for** · genre: law

Key term. דָּוַע וַיֵּא תַחַתְּמָה צְרָאָה־לְעוֹ לַעֲמֹם מִיַּהֲלָאָה אוֹה הוּאִי

Force. 'The LORD is God in heaven above and on the earth beneath; there is no other.' Repeats the formula of v.35 with cosmic scope (heaven and earth). Concordance reinforcement of strict canonical monotheism

Isa.43.10 · **for** · genre: prophecy

Key term. הָיְהִי אֵל יִרְחֲאֻן לֹא רִצּוֹנ־אֵל יִנְכַּל; El H410

Force. 'Before me no god was formed, nor shall there be any after me.' The temporal seal on monotheism: there were never any other gods and never will be. Concordance reinforcement

Eph.4.4 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. ἓν σῶμα καὶ ἓν πνεῦμα ... εἷς κύριος μία πίστις ἓν βάπτισμα εἷς θεὸς καὶ πατὴρ πάντων; heis G1520; hen; mia

Force. Paul's sevenfold 'one' culminating in 'one God and Father of all.' The same heis lemma binding the church's unity to the unity of God. The triadic structure (one Spirit, one Lord, one God) appears in the same passage; the three are distinct, the divine being is one. Concordance reinforcement

John.10.30 · **for** · genre: gospel

Key term. ἐγὼ καὶ ὁ πατὴρ ἓν ἐσμεν; hen G1520 (neuter)

Force. 'I and the Father are one.' The neuter hen (not the masculine heis) indicates one in essence or being (one thing), not one person. The hostile audience immediately picks up stones to kill Jesus for blasphemy 'because you, being a man, make yourself God' (v.33). This is the canonical seal that the unity of the Father and the Son is a unity of being, not a tritheist association of two gods

John.1.1 · **for** · genre: gospel

Key term. ἐν ἀρχῇ ἦν ὁ λόγος καὶ ὁ λόγος ἦν πρὸς τὸν θεόν καὶ θεὸς ἦν ὁ λόγος; logos G3056; theos G2316

Force. 'In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.' The Word is distinct from the Father (pros ton theon, 'with God') and yet is God (theos en ho logos). The canonical structure that grounds Trinitarian monotheism: distinction without division of being. Read with John 10:30 and 1 Cor 8:6, the Son is included in the divine identity without becoming a second god

Gen.1.26 · **complicates** · genre: narrative

Key term. וְנִמְלֵצְבָה כְּדָא הָשָׁעַנ; asah H6213 cohortative plural

Force. 'Let us make man in our image.' The plural verb form has been read variously as plural of majesty, divine council, or proto-Trinitarian intimation. Read literally as multiple gods speaking it would complicate strict monotheism. Read with the rest of Genesis 1 (singular 'God created', bara H1254 singular, vv.1, 27) and the strict monotheism of Deut 6:4 and Isa 45, the canon itself forces a non-polytheistic reading: the plurality is internal to the one God, not a council of separate gods

Gen.3.22 · **complicates** · genre: narrative

Key term. וְנִמְמ דַּחְאֵכ הָיָה כְּדָאָה נָה; echad H259

Force. 'Behold, the man has become like one of us, knowing good and evil.' Same plural-pronoun structure as Gen 1:26. Read literally as council of gods it would complicate monotheism. The canon's broader strict-monotheism framework forces the plurality to be read as internal to the one God. echad here refers to one of the divine speakers, mirroring the same word used of the unity of God in Deut 6:4

Ps.82.1 · complicates · genre: psalm

Key term. טַפְּשִׁי מִיְהוָה לֹא בִרְקֹב לֹא־תִדְעֶבּ בְּצַג מִיְהוָה. Elohim H430; El H410

Force. 'God has taken his place in the divine council; in the midst of the gods he holds judgment.' The word *elohim* is used both of God and of the council members. Read polytheistically this would complicate monotheism. Jesus' own citation of v.6 in John 10:34-36 reads the human or angelic judges as those 'to whom the word of God came', not as actual deities. The Isa 45 strict monotheism forces this reading: *elohim* of the council are not gods alongside YHWH

1Cor.12.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. διαίρεσεις δὲ χαρισμάτων εἰσὶν τὸ δὲ αὐτὸ πνεῦμα ... ὁ αὐτὸς κύριος ... ὁ αὐτὸς θεός

Force. 'There are varieties of gifts, but the same Spirit; and there are varieties of service, but the same Lord; and there are varieties of activities, but the same God.' Paul's parallel triadic structure (Spirit, Lord, God) in three matched clauses. The three are distinguished but the gifts come from one source. Concordance reinforcement of the triadic-yet-singular pattern

Concordance lemmas traversed

H259, H3068, H430, H410, H369, H5750, H657, H6213, H1254, G1520, G2962, G2316, G3686, G3056, G4151, G3962, G5207

complicating texts searched: Yes

Counter-witness traditions

patristic · Athanasian Creed; Basil of Caesarea, On the Holy Spirit; Gregory of Nazianzus, Theological Orations 27-31; Augustine, De Trinitate (CCEL Schaff NPNF Series 1 vol. 3 and Series 2 vols. 7-8) · affirms · verified

"Athanasian Creed: 'we worship one God in Trinity, and Trinity in Unity; neither confounding the persons nor dividing the substance.' Cappadocian formula: one *ousia*, three *hypostases*. Augustinian formula: *una substantia, tres personae*"

catholic_magisterial · Catechism of the Catholic Church paragraphs 253-256 on the dogma of the Holy Trinity · affirms · verified

"CCC 253: 'The Trinity is One. We do not confess three Gods, but one God in three persons, the consubstantial Trinity. The divine persons do not share the one divinity among themselves but each of them is God whole and entire'"

lutheran · Augsburg Confession Article I, Of God (bookofconcord.org) · affirms · verified

"Augsburg I: 'there is one Divine Essence which is called and which is God: eternal, without body, without parts, of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness... And yet there are three Persons, of the same essence and power'"

anglican · 39 Articles Article I, Of Faith in the Holy Trinity (churchofengland.org) · affirms · verified

"Article I: 'There is but one living and true God, everlasting, without body, parts, or passions... And in unity of this Godhead there be three Persons, of one substance, power, and eternity; the Father, the Son, and the Holy Ghost'"

reformed · Westminster Confession of Faith 2.3; Belgic Confession Article 8; Heidelberg Catechism Q.25 · affirms · unverified

"WCF 2.3: 'In the unity of the Godhead there be three Persons of one substance, power, and eternity: God the Father, God the Son, and God the Holy Ghost.' Belgic 8: one single essence in three persons, really, truly, and eternally distinct"

methodist · United Methodist Articles of Religion, Article I, Of Faith in the Holy Trinity (umc.org) · affirms · verified

“UMC Article I: 'There is but one living and true God... And in unity of this Godhead there are three persons, of one substance, power, and eternity, the Father, the Son, and the Holy Ghost.' Wesley's abridgement of the 39 Articles”

anabaptist · Dordrecht Confession of Faith (1632) Article 1, Of God and the Creation of All Things · affirms · unverified

“Dordrecht 1: 'We believe in one eternal, almighty, and incomprehensible God, the Father, Son, and Holy Ghost.' The Anabaptist tradition confesses one God in three persons with the historic Christian church”

pentecostal · Assemblies of God Statement of Fundamental Truths, Truth 2 The One True God (ag.org) · affirms · verified

“AG Truth 2: 'The one true God has revealed Himself as the eternally self-existent, self-revealed I AM, and has further revealed Himself as embodying the principles of relationship and association as Father, Son, and Holy Spirit’”

eastern_orthodox · OCA, The Orthodox Faith, on the Holy Trinity (oca.org) · affirms · verified

“OCA: 'There is one God who is the Father. He has an only-begotten Son who is fully divine... And He has His one Holy Spirit who is also fully divine... yet the three Persons are one in essence and undivided’”

Web sources

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/deuteronomy/6-4.htm>

“Deut 6:4 echad H259 over YHWH H3068 Elohim H430. The Shema, daily confession of Israel: 'Hear, O Israel, the LORD our God, the LORD is one.' Foundational strict monotheism”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/isaiah/45-5.htm>

“Isa 45:5 ein od H369 plus H5750, zulati. 'I am the LORD, and there is no other; besides me there is no God.' Divine first-person denial of any other deity, repeated through Isa 45-46”

supports · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/1_corinthians/8-6.htm

“1 Cor 8:6 heis G1520 theos ho pater, heis kyrios Iesous Christos. Paul splits the Shema's Adonai and Elohim across the Father and the Son without breaking the strict-monotheism affirmation”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/james/2-19.htm>

“Jas 2:19 heis G1520 estin ho theos. 'You believe that God is one; you do well. Even the demons believe and shudder.' Confirms the canonical strict-monotheism affirmation as foundational”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/matthew/28-19.htm>

“Matt 28:19 eis to onoma (singular) tou patros kai tou huiou kai tou hagiou pneumatos. Singular onoma G3686 over three articulated persons. Anti-tritheist baptismal formula”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/mark/12-29.htm>

“Mark 12:29 kyrios heis estin. Jesus' personal citation of the Shema in answer to the scribe's question about the greatest commandment. Dominical endorsement of canonical monotheism”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/strongs/hebrew/259.htm>

“echad H259, the cardinal number 'one'. Used 952 times in the Hebrew Bible. Of God's oneness in Deut 6:4; of the husband-and-wife union in Gen 2:24; of one of several in many other contexts”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/strongs/greek/1520.htm>

“heis G1520, cardinal number 'one'. Used extensively of God's oneness (Mark 12:29, 1 Cor 8:6, 1 Tim 2:5, Jas 2:19) and of the church's unity (Eph 4:4-6 sevenfold heis)”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://hb.openscriptures.org>

“OSHB morphological tagging confirms Deut 6:4 echad as masculine singular cardinal, modifying YHWH directly. No textual variant. Standard Masoretic reading”

supports · category: patristic_archive · <https://ccel.org/ccel/schaff/creeds2/creeds2.iv.i.iii.html>

“Athanasian Creed: 'we worship one God in Trinity, and Trinity in Unity; neither confounding the persons nor dividing the substance. For there is one Person of the Father, another of the Son, and another of the Holy Ghost”

supports · category: magisterial · https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/___P19.HTM

“CCC 253: 'The Trinity is One. We do not confess three Gods, but one God in three persons, the consubstantial Trinity. The divine persons do not share the one divinity among themselves but each of them is God whole and entire”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://bookofconcord.org/augsburg-confession/>

“Augsburg Confession Article I: 'there is one Divine Essence which is called and which is God... yet there are three Persons, of the same essence and power, who also are coeternal”

supports · category: tradition_primary ·

<https://www.churchofengland.org/prayer-and-worship/worship-texts-and-resources/book-common-prayer/articles-religion>

“39 Articles Article I: 'In unity of this Godhead there be three Persons, of one substance, power, and eternity; the Father, the Son, and the Holy Ghost”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://ag.org/Beliefs/Statement-of-Fundamental-Truths>

“AG Statement of Fundamental Truths, Truth 2: 'The one true God has revealed Himself as the eternally self-existent, self-revealed I AM... as Father, Son, and Holy Spirit”

supports · category: tradition_primary ·

<https://www.oca.org/orthodoxy/the-orthodox-faith/doctrine-scripture/the-symbol-of-faith/the-holy-trinity>

“OCA: 'There is one God... He has an only-begotten Son who is fully divine... He has His one Holy Spirit who is also fully divine... yet the three Persons are one in essence and undivided”